

PROTECTION OF THE SPINAL CORD

The spinal cord is located inside the spinal canal, which is a long tunnel within the aligned column of backbones (vertebrae). This vertebral column, along with its strengthening ligaments and muscles, bends and flexes the cord, but also guards it from direct knocks and blows. Within the spinal canal, the circulating cerebrospinal fluid (see p.89) acts as a shock-absorber and the epidural space provides a

cushioning layer of fat and connective tissue. The epidural tissues lie between the periosteum (the membrane that lines the bone of the spinal canal) and the dura mater, the outer layer of the meninges.

INSIDE THE SPINAL CANAL

A cross-section of the vertebral column in the neck (cervical) region shows how the spinal cord nestles in the well-padded bony cavity. Although the vertebrae shift position as the trunk of the body moves, the spinal cord remains well supported and protected.

